

ENGLISH FOR WORK / SEPTEMBER 2026

Supply Chain and Logistics English

Vocabulary & phrasebook

Keep precise meanings and useful expressions close. Retrieve the words, then use them in a complete message.

PRACTICE THAT TRANSFERS TO WORK

Read a realistic case. Find the right language. Speak, write, get feedback, and try again.

Eight lessons | Intermediate to advanced | Independent or classroom study

For supply-chain managers, planners, buyers, logistics coordinators, warehouse leaders, procurement teams, customs staff, and operations managers.

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

All scenarios, figures, and model responses are fictional teaching material. Use invented details in practice.

[Open this course on English Ladder](#)

Make vocabulary usable

Knowing a definition is a start. To use a term well, explain it in plain English, connect it to a case, and choose a natural sentence around it.

- Read five terms, cover their definitions, and recall the meanings.
- Sort a pair you might confuse and explain the difference.
- Use one term in a sentence about a fictional case.
- Ask a partner to explain the sentence without repeating the specialist word.
- Return to the same terms on another day and test recall again.

Abbreviations need context

Expand an abbreviation on first use when the listener needs it. Some abbreviations have different meanings across professions: API can refer to an application programming interface or an active pharmaceutical ingredient. The course context determines the meaning.

Definitions have limits

These are concise language-learning explanations, not complete legal, clinical, or technical specifications. Use the applicable authoritative definition for regulated or operational decisions.

Field vocabulary A-Z

allocation

The assignment of available resources, stock, or capacity to particular uses.

backlog

Ordered body of work waiting to be refined, prioritized, assigned, or completed.

broker

An intermediary who arranges transactions or services; duties depend on the field and arrangement.

business continuity

Planning to maintain or restore important operations during disruption.

carrier

A company that transports goods or people; in insurance, an insurer.

commercial invoice

A trade document describing the goods sold and relevant transaction details.

consensus plan

A plan developed from an agreed set of assumptions across relevant teams.

constraint

A limit that restricts the available choices or amount of work possible.

country of origin

The country attributed to goods under the applicable origin rules.

cycle count

A recurring count of selected inventory items to check record accuracy.

demand signal

Information suggesting what customers may require or purchase.

dual sourcing

Obtaining a product or service from two suppliers to support supply needs or continuity.

ETA

Estimated time of arrival; an estimate should be distinguished from a confirmed time.

expedite

To arrange faster handling or movement of an item.

forecast

Forward-looking estimate based on assumptions, trends, constraints, and known risks.

forecast bias

A systematic tendency for forecasts to be higher or lower than actual results.

HS code

A product classification code based on the Harmonized System used in international trade.

incoterms

International Chamber of Commerce trade terms allocating specified delivery responsibilities, costs, and risks.

lead time

The elapsed time between a defined request or start point and delivery or completion.

OTIF

On time, in full: a delivery measure evaluated against an agreed timing and quantity definition.

owner

Named person or role accountable for a decision, action, deliverable, or risk.

pick rate

The number of items or orders picked per stated unit of time.

purchase order

A buyer's formal document specifying goods or services ordered and relevant terms.

S&OP

Sales and operations planning: coordinating demand, supply, and business plans across teams.

safety stock

Inventory held to reduce the effect of variation in demand or supply.

scenario

A description of possible conditions used to explore decisions or practice responses.

service level

A defined standard of service performance, such as response timing or availability.

SKU

Stock keeping unit: an identifier for a distinct inventory item.

slotting

Assigning storage locations to warehouse items to support efficient handling.

stockout

A situation in which an item is unavailable when it is needed.

Expressions for this course

Complete the frames with the facts of your case. A frame helps organize meaning; it should not replace an actual explanation.

Match certainty to evidence

The available evidence shows

This may indicate ..., but

We have not yet established whether

Say what the evidence shows, identify what is still unknown, and limit the conclusion to that evidence. Words such as 'may', 'suggests', and 'in this sample' are useful when the uncertainty is real. Do not soften an urgent, verified safety concern.

Ask for an actionable next step

Could you provide ... so that ...?

Please confirm ... by [agreed time].

If that timing is not possible, please let me know

State the action and the information needed. Explain why it matters and specify a deadline only when one is given or agreed. 'Could you' is polite; repeated apologies can obscure a legitimate request. Urgent situations may require a direct request.

Make a complex point clear

In this context, ... means

The difference is that

How would you explain that distinction to a colleague?

Start with the reader's question. Explain one unfamiliar term with familiar words, then give a relevant example or contrast. Check understanding without asking only 'Do you understand?'.

Give a useful status update

We have completed ...; ... remains open.

As of ..., the status is

The next update will cover

Lead with the current state, then the important change or open item. Use completed-action language only for completed work. Add a next update point when it is known; do not invent a date to make the message sound complete.

Ask a precise question

When you say ..., do you mean ...?

Could you clarify which ...?

So, my understanding is Is that right?

Name the exact word, fact, or requirement you need clarified. Ask one focused question at a time. Repeat your understanding and give the other person a chance to correct it.

Explain a fair comparison

Both options ..., but

Option A ..., whereas option B

The comparison depends on

Use the same time period, scope, and measurement basis for both options. Explain a difference with 'whereas' or 'while'. State what improves and what is given up; do not hide the weaker side of a recommendation.

Help a group reach a clear next step

Let's hear ... before we decide.

The point we still need to resolve is

Who will make this decision, and what do they need?

Summarize the issue neutrally, invite missing perspectives, and distinguish discussion from decision. State who can decide and record any unresolved question. Do not assume silence means agreement.

Model responses in context

Read the situation first. Cover the model, say your own response, and compare the two for meaning and tone.

01 | Demand Planning and Forecast Bias

A forecast exceeds actual demand for three months. Sales expects a new promotion to improve demand but has no order evidence yet.

The forecast has been above actual demand for three months. The promotion may change that pattern, but it is still an assumption. I'll separate confirmed orders from the promotional estimate.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

02 | Procurement and Supplier Performance

A supplier acknowledges an order but gives no shipping date. The planning team needs a date to update its schedule.

Could you confirm the planned ship date and any quantity that will remain outstanding? Please distinguish a confirmed commitment from a provisional estimate so we can update the schedule accurately.

Try it again: The other person cannot meet the requested timing. Clarify an alternative without inventing authority to change a formal deadline.

03 | Inventory, Safety Stock, and Service Levels

A warehouse has high total inventory but repeated stockouts of two important items. A manager asks why the headline total looks healthy.

The total inventory value hides differences between items. We have stock in some products but shortages in two others. Let's review availability by item and expected demand.

Try it again: Your listener is new to this field. Replace two specialist expressions with clear explanations without changing the meaning.

04 | Warehousing and Fulfillment

A fulfillment team starts with 300 open orders and ships 220. Fifty new orders arrive during the shift.

We shipped 220 orders, and 50 new orders arrived. The backlog is now 130 orders. I'll include both completed work and incoming demand so the change is clear.

Try it again: The listener asks you to reduce the update to two sentences. Preserve the most important completed and pending items.

05 | Freight, Routing, and Carrier Delays

A carrier estimates delivery on Wednesday but has not confirmed departure. A customer asks for a guaranteed arrival time.

Wednesday is the carrier's current estimate, not a confirmed arrival. Departure is still pending. I'll send the next update when the carrier confirms the shipment status.

Try it again: Someone asks for a yes-or-no answer when the evidence supports only a qualified answer. Be concise while preserving the uncertainty.

06 | Customs, Trade Compliance, and Documentation

A shipment file contains different product descriptions on the invoice and packing list. The broker requests clarification.

The descriptions do not match across the documents. Could the responsible team confirm the correct product details and provide consistent records for the broker's review?

Try it again: The other person uses an ambiguous word such as 'ready', 'approved', or 'urgent'. Clarify it before continuing.

07 | Supply Risk and Business Continuity

One supplier has a shorter lead time; a second has available backup capacity. The team is considering supply continuity options.

The first supplier offers speed, while the second may provide backup capacity. Let's compare availability, qualification status, and switching constraints before treating either option as a complete continuity solution.

Try it again: Your listener focuses only on the lowest price or fastest date. Explain one other relevant comparison criterion.

08 | Executive S&OP Decisions

Sales and operations propose different monthly plans. The meeting has ten minutes left and no agreed assumption about the promotion.

The unresolved assumption is promotional demand. Could we compare the two plans using the same assumption, then record the chosen plan, its owner, and the condition that would trigger a review?

Try it again: A participant interrupts or the meeting is running out of time. Protect a turn to speak and close with an accurate decision record.

Use the language responsibly

All cases and figures are fictional. Adapt the language to your role and organization's current procedures, using invented details for practice.

Meaning before performance

Use specialist terms only when they help the listener. Explain unfamiliar words, preserve uncertainty, and ask when an instruction or responsibility is unclear. The model responses illustrate language; they do not authorize professional actions.

Sources and further reading

The cases, workshops, and explanations are original teaching material. These references provide language frameworks and selected professional context. References were checked in September 2026; consult current local guidance for actual work.

Digital.gov: plain-language guidance

<https://digital.gov/guides/plain-language>

Council of Europe: CEFR descriptors

<https://www.coe.int/en/web/common-european-framework-reference-languages/cefr-descriptors>

Your next step

Choose one expression you can use in a genuine work situation. Rehearse it with fictional details, then adapt the wording to your role and audience.